

Customer & MVP Blueprint

AI-Powered Career Platform for College Students (India) | Built from the Startup Validation Report dated 3 Oct 2026 |

Stage: concept / early MVP

Extracted from your Validation Report

Item	What the report says
Startup idea	AI-powered career platform for Indian college students: roadmaps, skill-gap analysis, readiness scoring, mocks, resume/project guidance.
Problem	Students don't know what to learn next, can't tell if they are job-ready, and juggle 4-6 disconnected tools. Employability is 56.35% (India Skills Report 2026); graduate unemployment ~11.2% (PLFS 2025, secondary).
Target customers	B2C: 2nd/3rd-year CSE/IT/AI/ML students at tier-2/3 colleges. B2B: Training & Placement Officers (TPOs) at private engineering colleges with 300+ CS students.
Competitors	Generic AI (ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude) - High threat; early 'AI career OS' startups (MentorWise AI, UniqueBy AI) - High; bootcamps (Scaler, Coding Ninjas, upGrad), DSA sites (LeetCode, GfG), job boards (Internshala, Unstop, LinkedIn), PrepInsta - Medium/Low.
Validation insights	Overall 58/100, Conditional Go. Secondary evidence is strong, primary evidence is 2/10 (zero interviews or surveys) . Real white space = verified proof-of-work and college analytics; roadmaps are a feature, not a business. Founder fit 6.0/10: strong builder, weak distribution/GTM.

1. Executive Summary

Verdict: Promising but Unvalidated. The pain is real and well documented in secondary data, and the beachhead is clear. But every number about willingness to pay, retention and 'better than ChatGPT' is still an assumption. The product should start as a **narrow, concierge-style Job-Readiness Check with a 7-day visible win**, not a full 'career OS'. Success in 30 days = 30+ interviews, 40%+ four-week pilot retention, and 8%+ of students paying or 3+ colleges committing.

- Who:** Aarav, a 2nd/3rd-year CSE/IT/AI/ML student at a tier-2/3 college who wants an internship, then a first software/ML role.
- Wedge:** 'Am I job-ready for role X?' - unify resume + public GitHub + practice data into one benchmarked score and a weekly plan.
- Moat to build:** verified progress data and AI-evaluated project proof-of-work, later sold to colleges and employers (the report's top two pivots).
- Biggest unknown:** will students or colleges pay, given free LLMs? India-only B2C at INR 1,500/student is a good business but not venture-scale (SAM INR 106 cr).

2. Ideal Customer Profile (ICP)

Attribute	Beachhead ICP (B2C)	Secondary ICP (B2B)
Segment	2nd/3rd-year CSE/IT/AI/ML students, tier-2/3 private colleges, outside metros	Private engineering colleges with 300+ CS students; ~1,200 reachable of 5,875
Goal	Internship within 6-9 months, then a strong first role	Higher placement rate and package; NAAC/NIRF metrics
Current tools	YouTube, LeetCode, GfG, ChatGPT, LinkedIn	Spreadsheets, training vendors, recruiter drives
Where to find	Reels, YouTube, campus ambassadors, Discord, college WhatsApp groups	TPO networks, events, referrals, free pilot
Budget (assumed)	Free to INR 500/mo; parents pay for clear outcomes	INR 1.5-3 lakh/yr per cohort
Disqualifiers	Final-year students with offers; non-tech branches (for now)	Colleges with entrenched all-in-one vendor and no analytics gap

Recommendation: pick ONE role track for the pilot (e.g. 'SDE intern' or 'AI/ML intern'), not both. The report lists the AI/ML track as a medium-potential pivot that plays to the founder's computer-vision strength.

3. Buyer Persona

	Aarav - User and payer (B2C)	Mr. Sharma, TPO - Economic buyer (B2B)
Profile	20, 3rd-year CSE, tier-2 college, family wants a job within a year	45, Training & Placement Officer, 300+ CS students, answers to management and parents
Motivation	Fear of missing placement season; wants a clear path and proof he can show recruiters	Placement percentage, package, NAAC/NIRF reporting, finding at-risk students early
Frustration	Generic AI roadmaps, scattered tools, resume ignored, no honest feedback	No data on who is ready; vendors sell content, not readiness analytics
Decision rule	Pays if he sees visible progress in 7 days and it beats ChatGPT; parents approve bigger spends	Needs a free pilot, visible dashboard within a month, low admin effort, a peer college reference
Objection	'ChatGPT is free'; 'Will it get me hired?'	'We already have a vendor'; 'Another tool for faculty to manage'

4. Top 10 Customer Pain Points

#	Pain point	Sev.	Source	Product opportunity
1	Don't know what to learn next or in what order	9	Report	Adaptive weekly plan
2	Can't tell whether they are job-ready	9	Report	Role-benchmarked readiness score
3	Unsure which projects stand out; resume ignored by ATS	8	Report	Role-specific project briefs, ATS-aware resume check
4	Interview anxiety, no feedback; no mentor outside metros	8	Report	AI mock interviews (later), mentor network (later)
5	Too many disconnected tools; motivation drops	7	Report	One dashboard, streaks, cohorts
6	No credible proof of skill beyond a degree (tier-2/3 stigma)	8	Hypothesis	AI-evaluated project credential
7	Failed online assessments with no idea why	7	Hypothesis	Gap diagnosis from practice data
8	AI-chatbot advice feels generic and is not tracked	7	Report (H3)	Progress-aware, accountable plan
9	Bootcamps are expensive and fixed-curriculum	6	Report	Low-cost personalised alternative
10	Colleges can't see who is placement-ready until too late	8 (B2B)	Report (gap 4)	TPO dashboard, at-risk alerts

'Hypothesis' items were inferred from the report's context, not from interviews. Validate or discard them in Week 1-2.

5. Customer Journey

Stage	Customer behaviour	Touchpoint	What we must deliver	Metric
Awareness	Sees a peer's internship win or fails an OA; searches 'how to get placed'	Reels, YouTube, ambassadors, college WhatsApp	Free, shareable 'Job-Readiness Check' hook	Landing visits (300+), waitlist (100+)
Consideration	Compares with ChatGPT, YouTube, bootcamps	Free resume + GitHub gap report, 5-minute roadmap	A result noticeably better than a one-prompt LLM answer	Report completion %, side-by-side win rate
Purchase	Pays when the free value is proven and a deadline is near	Paywall on mocks, project reviews, credential; college pilot to paid	Clear outcome promise, fair price, parent-friendly proof	Pay or pre-commit rate (target 8%+), colleges (3+)
Retention	Returns weekly if progress is visible	Weekly plan, streaks, cohorts, nudges	First visible win in 7 days; weekly ritual	4-week retention 40%+, weekly active

Critical moment (from the report): activation to habit. No visible improvement within 7 days means churn.

6. Key Customer Objections

Objection	Likelihood	Response
'ChatGPT is free'	Very high	Show tracking, verification and accountability that an LLM cannot give; run a side-by-side test
'Will it actually get me hired?'	High	Publish outcomes, testimonials, recruiter-visible portfolio
'I won't pay / my parents won't pay'	High	Free core; charge for mocks, reviews, credentials; or the college pays
'Is my data safe?' (GitHub, resume)	Medium	Consent, deletion controls, DPDP-aware design; public GitHub only at first
College: 'we already have a vendor'	Medium	Position as analytics layer on top of existing training; free pilot

7. Key Buying Triggers

- **Placement season 6-9 months away** - urgency peaks for 3rd/pre-final-year students.
- **Failed online assessment** or rejected resume - pain is fresh and specific.
- **A peer lands an internship** - social proof and fear of falling behind.
- **College sets placement targets** (B2B) - TPOs need data and a visible improvement plan.
- **Parent pressure** - parents pay when outcomes are credible (hypothesis, test in interviews).

8. MVP Recommendation

Build first: a 'Job-Readiness Check' for ONE role track. Input: resume + public GitHub + a short skills quiz. Output: a role-benchmarked readiness score, top 3 gaps, a 4-week plan and one role-specific project brief. Run it **concierge-style** (manual plus LLM assist) for 25-30 students before automating. This follows the report's instruction: validate 30 days, do not build more product yet.

Build first	Do NOT build yet (and why)	Success metrics (30 days)
• Landing page + readiness check • Resume + GitHub gap report • Weekly plan with check-ins (WhatsApp or simple web) • First-win design: one visible improvement in 7 days • Simple progress dashboard for the pilot cohort • Manual TPO summary sheet for 2 pilot colleges	• Mobile app - web/WhatsApp is enough to test demand • AI mock-interview engine - costly, unproven pull • Mentor marketplace - supply-side complexity • Full college dashboard - sell with a sheet first • Job board / integrations - Internshala and LinkedIn own discovery • Multi-role roadmaps - an LLM already does this free	• 30+ interviews, 60%+ rate problem 7+/10 • 100+ waitlist from 300+ visits • 40%+ four-week retention (25-30 pilot students) • 8%+ pay or pre-commit, or 3+ colleges commit • Beat ChatGPT in side-by-side with 10 students • 5 testimonials

9. MoSCoW Prioritization

Priority	Features / scope
Must Have	One role track; readiness score vs role benchmark; resume + public GitHub analysis; top-3 gap report; 4-week adaptive plan; weekly check-in and progress tracking; consent and data-deletion; interview log and metrics sheet
Should Have	Role-specific project brief with rubric; ATS-aware resume feedback; cohort/streak mechanics; shareable readiness card (growth loop); simple payment or pre-commit link; TPO summary report
Could Have	AI project evaluation (first version of proof-of-work); practice-platform data import (LeetCode/GfG); AI mock interview (limited); referral rewards; second role track (AI/ML)
Won't Have (now)	Native app; mentor marketplace; job board; recruiter portal; full college SaaS; multi-country support; certification with employer endorsement (until employers adopt)

10. Pricing Hypothesis

Offer	Hypothesis (INR, to test)	Rationale
Free core	Readiness check, gap report, 4-week plan	Acquisition hook; removes 'I won't pay' objection
Student Plus	199/mo vs 499/mo vs 1,499/yr (test all 3)	Report assumes INR 1,500/yr; need 5,000-15,000 ARPU for venture scale, so add paid outcomes
Pay-per-use	Project review 199-499; mock interview 99-199; credential 999 one-time	Lets students pay only at the moment of need (placement season)
College pilot	Free 4 weeks, then INR 1.5-3 lakh/yr per cohort	Matches report's B2B assumption; priced against vendor budgets
Later	Recruiter / hiring-pipeline fees	Highest ARPU; only after verified data exists

All prices are assumptions. The 30-day test should show which price point yields 8%+ pay or pre-commit.

11. Top 5 Risks

#	Risk	L / I	Mitigation
1	Free LLMs commoditise roadmaps (R1)	5 / 5	Own verified progress data, accountability, outcomes; side-by-side test early
2	Low willingness to pay (R2)	4 / 5	Test 3 price points in Week 2; add B2B and outcome-linked revenue
3	Weak retention (R3)	4 / 4	Weekly rituals, cohorts, nudges; design for first win in 7 days
4	Slow college sales and GTM gap for a solo tech founder (R4, R6)	3-4 / 3-4	Free pilots, growth/sales co-founder, ambassadors, build in public
5	Building on assumptions: zero primary evidence, plus DPDP privacy (R7)	3 / 4	30+ interviews before any new build; consent and deletion controls from day one

12. 30-Day MVP Plan

Week	Focus	Key activities	Deliverable / gate
1	Define and discover	Pick one segment + role; write interview script; recruit 40 students; run 10 interviews; draft readiness rubric	Pain list; chosen wedge
2	Demand test	Finish 30+ interviews; launch landing page with Job-Readiness Check (300+ visits); test 3 price points; talk to 5 TPOs	100+ waitlist; pricing data
3	Concierge pilot	Run pilot with 25-30 students; side-by-side vs ChatGPT with 10; offer free pilot to 2 colleges; track weekly activity	Retention and first-win data
4	Decide	Analyse against decision table; collect 5 testimonials; Go / Pivot / No-Go; plan 90-day build	Decision memo

Metric	GO	PIVOT	NO-GO
Interviews done	30+	20-29	<15
Students rating problem 7+/10	60%+	40-59%	<40%
Pilot 4-week retention	40%+	20-39%	<20%
Pay or pre-commit	8%+ or 3+ colleges	3-7%	<3%
Side-by-side vs ChatGPT	Yours preferred	Split	ChatGPT preferred

13. Founder Action Sheet - Top 10 Next Actions

#	Action	Owner / timing
1	Choose ONE role track and ONE college tier; write it as a one-line wedge statement	Founder - Day 1
2	Write the interview script covering pain, current tools, ChatGPT use and willingness to pay	Founder - Day 1-2
3	Recruit 40 students via college WhatsApp groups, Discord, LinkedIn and campus contacts	Founder - Week 1
4	Run 2 interviews daily; log every one in a single sheet with tagged quotes	Founder - Daily
5	Build the landing page and Job-Readiness Check form (no-code or minimal code)	Founder - Week 1-2
6	Define the readiness rubric and 7-day 'first win' for the chosen role	Founder - Week 2
7	Test 3 price points on the landing page and in interviews; record pre-commits	Founder - Week 2
8	Meet 5 TPOs; offer a free pilot to 2 colleges with a one-page summary	Founder + advisor - Week 2-3
9	Run the concierge pilot and the side-by-side ChatGPT test; track weekly activity	Founder - Week 3-4
10	Start recruiting a growth/sales co-founder; post one build-in-public update weekly	Founder - Ongoing

14. Scores (0-100)

Score	Value	Why
Customer Clarity	68	ICP and persona are specific; B2B persona and willingness to pay not yet confirmed by interviews
Problem Severity	72	Matches report problem score; strong secondary data, but primary evidence is only 2/10
PMF Potential	45	Free-LLM competition (40) and monetization (45) hold this back; white space exists in proof-of-work and college analytics
MVP Readiness	40	Wedge not yet chosen, no pilot data, concept/early MVP stage; but a lean concierge MVP is quick to start

15. Final Verdict

PROMISING BUT UNVALIDATED (yellow signal)

Scale	Meaning	Status
GREEN - Strong Demand Signal	Primary evidence of demand and payment	Not yet
YELLOW - Promising but Unvalidated	Real problem, clear ICP, no primary proof of demand or payment	Current
ORANGE - Weak Demand Signal	Interviews show lukewarm pull or ChatGPT preferred	Possible after Week 4
RED - Low Demand Probability	Little pull in interviews; under 3% pay or pre-commit	Possible after Week 4

Upgrade to GREEN if, within 30 days, 40%+ of pilot students stay weekly-active for 4 weeks and 8%+ pay or pre-commit (or 3+ colleges commit). If ChatGPT is preferred side-by-side, move to the college placement-readiness SaaS or verified skill portfolio pivots. Scores and prices are advisor judgments based on your report, not primary research; this is not financial or investment advice.